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INDIA WAS FOUND WANTING IN ITS NEIGHBOURHOOD. RELATIONS WITH CHINA NOSEDIVED AND IT GOT tough over the border dispute. In Sri Lanka, India was not able to persuade President Rajapakse to come out with a grand gesture towards the Tamils after Prabhakaran's death.

REUTERS



Hu Jintao with Manmohan (top); the body of LTTE chief Prabhakaran (left) and Sri Lankan President Mahinda Rajapakse

AP



relations but India is yet to cement ties and is expected to do so only in the second week of January when she pays a state visit.

It is in its relations with China though, that things seem to have taken a turn for the worse. China hardened its stance on the border issue with India reopening old issues such as the legitimacy of Arunachal Pradesh. Border intrusions by China—though South Block dis-

missed it as normal—saw growing hysteria in the nation about “the Chinese threat”. When China protested against Dalai Lama visiting the Tawang monastery in Arunachal, India proved a point by refusing to yield. It was a gutsy act because under Chinese pressure, even Obama had agreed not to meet the Dalai Lama on his trip to the US and the British Foreign Ministry acknowledged China's sovereignty

over Tibet. Now as Shivshankar Menon, a former foreign secretary and an expert on China, says: “We need to recalibrate our relationship with the Chinese and find a new equilibrium with them. Rather than a big bang approach to discuss all outstanding issues, it is best we take smaller steps and find common ground on issues like maritime security and on climate change.”

On regional issues, the

UPA's performance is mixed. SAARC continues to be dysfunctional. But on ASEAN, the UPA has finally set the ball rolling by signing the Free Trade Agreement. At the end of the year, Manmohan broke new ground on climate change as he did with the nuclear deal. Even as the Opposition screamed “sell-out”, he encouraged Environment Minister Jairam Ramesh to chalk out a bold new policy on climate change in consonance with China, Brazil and South Africa—the so called BASIC group—that upstaged Europe as a key player and helped thrash out the Copenhagen Accord with the US.

In 2010, the Middle East and Africa—that have been conspicuously absent from Manmohan's tour itineraries—should be on top of the list. With Pakistan, India's policy will have to be wait-and-watch. As Manmohan himself admitted, “We still don't know who to deal with.” Maybe the dialogue can resume with initially a single focus on curbing terrorism. In Afghanistan, India needs to step up its watch.

Pressure will mount on India to sign the CTBT with Obama signalling that nuclear disarmament would be his administration's priority. Sorting wro issues would also be top on the international agenda as is a revamp of the UN Security Council to include India as a permanent member. It's a full plate and Krishna and his colleagues have the chance to make a decisive difference in 2010. They should do so with confidence for India has truly arrived on the global stage. ■